

Aquifer Open Study Notes

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Aquifer Open Study Notes

Haggai 1:1

This introductory statement (*superscription*) identifies the author, the audience, the date, and the occasion prompting the prophecy. • the second year: King Darius I (Hystaspes) ruled Persia 521–486 BC, early in the Persian Empire (539–331 BC). The messages of Haggai are among the most precisely dated prophecies in the Old Testament. • Prophet (Hebrew *nabi*) designates Haggai as a representative of God who speaks with the authority of God, who sent him. • Zerubbabel led one group of Hebrews back to Palestine after the Babylonian exile and was the Persian-appointed governor of Judah at the time of Haggai's ministry (see [Ezra 2:1–2](#); [3:2](#); [Neh 7:7](#)). • Jeshua was the high priest at that time. Under his supervision, the altar was rebuilt and the second Temple was dedicated ([Ezra 3:2](#); [5:2](#); [6:15](#)).

Haggai 1:1–15

The first message calls the people of Jerusalem to focus on restoring proper worship of God.

Haggai 1:2

Lord of Heaven's Armies: Haggai's and Zechariah's favorite expression for God emphasizes the invincible power behind God's word. The Lord can call on infinite numbers of heavenly troops to carry out his will at a moment's notice ([2 Kgs 6:17](#); [Matt 26:53](#)). This thought was intended to encourage the Judeans, who felt helpless and insignificant. • The time has not yet come: Poor crop yields from drought and pestilence had so weakened Judah's economy ([Hag 1:6](#), [9–11](#)) that the people thought they could not afford to rebuild the Temple. Haggai convinced them they could not afford to leave the Temple in ruins, for God would not bless and prosper them if they did not rebuild the Lord's house ([1:4](#), [7–8](#)).

Haggai 1:4

Why are you? Rhetorical questions in prophetic literature call for agreement rather than a reply (see [2:3](#)). The purpose of this question is to remove the listeners' opportunity to offer excuses in response to the message. • The luxurious (or *covered*, *paneled*) houses of the people contrasted with God's Temple, which was in ruins (or *desolate*) and thus unusable.

Haggai 1:5

Look at what's happening to you (literally *Set your heart on these matters*): For the Hebrews, the *heart* is the place where thinking, feeling, and willing all occur. So this command (also [1:7](#); [2:15](#), [18](#)) calls upon the people to think carefully and draw the proper conclusions about the connection between what's happening to them (drought and poverty, [1:6](#)) and their failure to restore proper worship of the Lord ([1:8–9](#)).

Haggai 1:6

eat . . . drink . . . put on clothes: Each of these conveys continuous action (i.e., you keep filling your plates . . . you keep drinking and drinking . . . you put on layer after layer of clothes), heightening the sense of futility. • pockets filled with holes (literally *a pierced bag*): The image depicts the loss of wages. Many families faced poverty despite their steady labors.

Haggai 1:8

Now go up into the hills: The stands of trees around Jerusalem were insufficient to meet the demands of the Temple project. Such supplies would have been imported from Lebanon and Syria to the north. • The challenge to rebuild my house underscores the importance of worship in the life of the community and the need for a proper sanctuary so worship of the Lord might take place according to the law. The land would experience blessing and prosperity when the Lord's Temple—his dwelling place—was rebuilt ([2:4](#)).

Haggai 1:9

I blew it away: The Lord destroyed the harvest because the people's priorities were wrong—they thought only of themselves rather than of God. • says the Lord of Heaven's Armies: The "God-as-speaker formula," which often closes a prophecy ([1:13](#); [2:8](#), [17](#), [23](#)), verified Haggai's message as the sure word of God.

Haggai 1:11

I have called for a drought: The people failed to recognize their plight as a divine judgment on their misplaced priorities, so Haggai interpreted the situation in light of the curses attached to the covenant ([Deut 28:15–68](#), especially vv [22–24](#), [38–40](#)). • Drought (Hebrew *khoreb*) is a wordplay on "ruins" ([Hag 1:4](#), [9](#); Hebrew *khareb*)—Judah's experiences corresponded with the condition in which they had left the Lord's Temple.

Haggai 1:12

The whole remnant means the people who returned from Babylon. All of them were united in the rebuilding project. • the people feared the Lord: They responded with reverence and worship, and they reordered their priorities by placing spiritual values above their material prosperity.

Haggai 1:13

Haggai's unusual title as the Lord's messenger (the same Hebrew phrase is often translated *angel of the Lord*) ascribes distinctive authority to Haggai as the Lord's agent. • I am with you: This affirmed God's covenant with the people of Judea, his personal presence, and his support in the building project ([2:4–5](#); see [Gen 26:3](#); [Exod 3:12](#); [Isa 41:10](#); [43:5](#); [Jer 30:11](#)).

Haggai 1:14

The Lord sparked the enthusiasm (literally *stirred the spirit*) of the people to accomplish his purposes (see [Ezra 1:1](#); [Isa 13:17](#); [41:25](#); [Jer 51:1](#), [11](#)). True

worship of God prompts sacrificial service by God's people.

Haggai 2:1

on October 17 of that same year: This was the last day of the Festival of Tabernacles, the celebration of the summer harvest (see [Lev 23:34–43](#)). Hundreds of years earlier, Solomon's Temple had been dedicated during this festival ([1 Kgs 8:2](#)). Haggai's message was timed to offer the people hope and encouragement in their present distress and discouragement.

Haggai 2:1–9

Haggai's second message assures the community that God has not forgotten his promises, made by earlier prophets, to bless and restore them (e.g., [Isa 35](#); [40:1–11](#); [52:1–12](#); [Jer 32:36–44](#); [33:6–26](#)).

Haggai 2:3

The former splendor belonged to Solomon's Temple ([1 Kgs 6:38](#)), which some of the older people of Judah had seen in their youth before going into exile in Babylon. They wept when they saw the new foundation laid ([Ezra 3:12–13](#)), because it seemed like nothing at all by comparison.

Haggai 2:4

But now . . . Be strong: This marks a shift from rebuke and challenge to encouragement and affirmation (cp. [Josh 1:6–7](#)).

Haggai 2:5

My Spirit remains among you: See [Exod 29:46](#); [Isa 63:11](#); [Ezek 36:26–27](#). • just as I promised (literally *the word I cut with you*): The phrase "cut a covenant" is the Hebrew idiom for making a covenant (see [Gen 15:18](#); [Exod 34:27](#)). Haggai's phrase, "cut a word," is unique in the Old Testament, using language that purposefully creates a connection between his prophecy and God's covenant relationship with his people. By making this connection, Haggai underscored the

continuity of God's actions in rescuing his people, first from Egypt and then from Babylon (see [Ezek 20:33–38](#)).

Haggai 2:6–7

God will again shake the heavens and the earth at the coming day of judgment (see [Isa 2:19–21](#); [30:28](#)). The previous shaking was the judgment on Egypt at the time of the Exodus ([Hag 2:21–22](#); [Exod 14:31](#)). The New Testament relates in just a little while to the return of Jesus Christ ([Heb 12:26–27](#)). Haggai probably saw God's ultimate judgment foreshadowed in events to take place after his time (e.g., the fall of Persia to Greece, the fall of Greece to Rome; see [Dan 2:39–45](#)).

Haggai 2:7

Treasures . . . will be brought to the Temple by all the nations as tribute and homage to the God of Israel.

Haggai 2:9

future glory: Haggai might have in mind the Messiah's coming to his Temple (see [Mal 3:1](#)). Jesus was presented in the Lord's Temple as an infant ([Luke 2:22](#)), and he taught there as an adult ([Luke 19:45–47](#)). Jesus, the human Word of God, is greater than the Temple ([Matt 12:6](#); see [John 2:13–22](#)). Although it was recognized by only a few, Jesus' presence in the Temple far outshone the glory in the Tabernacle at the time of Moses and in Solomon's Temple (cp. [Luke 2:29–32](#)). • in this place I will bring peace: The priestly benediction ([Num 6:24–26](#)) was pronounced as part of the Temple liturgy. In the last days, God would make a covenant of peace with Israel ([Ezek 34:25](#); [37:26](#)). The good result of rebuilding the Temple was a guarantee on that future *peace*.

Haggai 2:10–19

The theme of the third message is the law's instructions about ritual purity. These instructions were still operative. God expects his people to be holy, even as he is holy ([Lev 11:44–45](#)).

Haggai 2:11

Ask the priests: The priests' job was to teach and interpret the law ([Deut 33:10](#); [Mal 2:7–9](#)), so the message about ceremonial purity was directed to them.

Haggai 2:12

will it also become holy? This question refers to meat from a holy sacrifice and the way in which ceremonial purity and impurity could be transferred (see "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note). Carrying the holy sacrifice—the meat set aside and prepared for the offering—rendered one's robe holy (cp. [Lev 6:18](#)). This holiness, however, could not be transmitted to a third object.

Haggai 2:13

Ceremonial uncleanness is transmitted much more easily than ceremonial purity. Anyone touching a corpse became defiled and thus unclean. Anything touched by a ceremonially unclean person was also rendered impure (see [Num 19:11–13](#), [22](#)). Haggai applies this in [Hag 2:14](#).

Haggai 2:14

That is how it is with this people: Simply returning from exile to the land God promised Israel did not make the people of Judah holy. They were still unclean, since they were not obeying the instructions of God's covenant with them. Their work and even their worship were contaminated by impurity; the ruins of the Lord's Temple had symbolized the people's disobedience. The rebuilding of the Temple was a tangible sign of changed hearts and renewed obedience to God's covenant.

Haggai 2:15

Look at what was happening (see study note on 1:5): Divine blessing, whether spiritual or material, is contingent upon the obedience of God's people ([Deut 30:6–10](#)). Haggai called the people to persist in the self-examination that leads to repentance and in the fear of the Lord that his first message initiated (see [Hag 1:7](#), [12](#)).

Haggai 2:17

Return often signifies repentance. • you refused: The Hebrew people were stubborn and rebellious from the time of Moses ([Deut 31:27](#)) to the time of Jesus ([Matt 17:17](#)). • blight and mildew: What happened was the result of disobedience to God's covenant (see [Deut 28:22](#)).

Haggai 2:18

Think about this eighteenth day of December, the day: Or *On this eighteenth day of December, think about the day*; literally *Think about this day onward, this twenty-fourth day of the ninth month*. Some believe that the phrase "this day" refers to the date of the initial clearing of rubble from the Temple site and the procuring of building materials (September 21, 520 BC; see [1:14-15](#)).

Haggai 2:19

I am giving you a promise now while the seed is still in the barn: The promise of a bountiful crop calls attention to God's faithfulness to his covenant people. The Temple was not yet complete, but God was promising to extend its blessings at once. • But from this day onward I will bless you: God was gracious in responding immediately to his people's efforts toward spiritual renewal and obedience (see [Ps 111:4-5](#)).

Haggai 2:20-23

Haggai's final message is perhaps the most important; it reestablishes the prominence of David's descendant in Israel's religious and political life. The dynasty of David was key to restoring the Hebrew people after the Babylonian exile (see [Jer 23:5](#); [Ezek 37:24](#)). God had cursed David's descendant, King Jehoiachin, at the time of the Exile ([Jer 22:24-30](#)), but Haggai's last message overturns that curse and reinstates the covenant with David (see [2 Sam 7:4-17](#)) as the means by which God will carry out his promises to bless and restore Israel.

Haggai 2:21

Zerubbabel, the governor, was a descendant of David through Jehoiachin ([1 Chr 3:19](#)). Haggai's affirmation thus overturns the curse on Jehoiachin ([Jer 22:24-30](#)). However, Zerubbabel abruptly disappears from the biblical record. He was possibly deposed as Judean governor or even executed by King Darius, who was attempting to control his newly acquired empire. The expectations here ascribed to Zerubbabel, and his status as a descendant of David, might have made him a political threat to Darius.

Haggai 2:22

I will overturn their chariots and riders: The prophet's language would remind Israel of their deliverance from the Egyptian army (see [Exod 15:1-21](#)). The ambiguity of the threat of God's judgment makes it unclear whether Haggai is referring to events in the distant future or to something more immediate involving the Persian Empire (e.g., the Greek-Persian wars during the reigns of Darius I and Xerxes or the later Peloponnesian War).

Haggai 2:23

The signet ring was a symbol of kingship. An engraved stone set in a gold or silver finger ring was used to seal or endorse official documents. The image here emphasizes the divine authority invested in Zerubbabel and assures the people of God's continuing involvement in the political process (despite the failures of the Hebrew monarchs). The designation of Zerubbabel as the *signet* of the Lord no doubt rekindled expectations for the Messiah, since Zerubbabel was a descendant of King David. Yet the declaration ultimately points beyond Zerubbabel (see study note on 2:21) to one of his descendants (see [Matt 1:12](#); [Luke 1:32-33](#); [3:27](#)).